in peace and freedom from fear and in true health through the purity and essence of our natural fluids.'[45] When General Turgidson reads the message to President Muffley, he explains that 'we're still trying to figure out the meaning of that last phrase, sir'. Muffley retorts: 'There's nothing to figure out, General Turgidson. This man is obviously a psychotic.'[46] The general smiles: 'I'd like to hold off judgment on a thing like that, Mister President, until all the facts are in.'

There are, of course, problems in knowing when 'all the facts are in'. Some facts are never in. Some change. Some are ambiguous. The nature, importance, and interpretation of facts are frequently the subject of debate and disagreement. These simplistic observations are, nevertheless, important when trying to draw lessons. The best example is the golden bridge of Kennedy's pledge not to invade Cuba in return for withdrawal of the missiles (and bombers). A sensible lesson would seem that it is prudent to give the adversary a means of saving their face. This is especially so if the adversary is armed with nuclear weapons.

Once it became known (in the late 1980s) that Kennedy offered a secret deal on the Turkish (and Italian) Jupiters, that changed the basis for interpretation (and presumably for the lessons to be drawn). It might be claimed that Khrushchev had built a bridge of sorts behind Kennedy (though one that his allies were not supposed to know about). The lesson that could now be drawn was not to avoid appeasement but to pursue it more adeptly. Yet, what then emerged with Fursenko and Naftali's revelations in 1997 and 2005 (discussed in chapter six) was that gilding the golden bridge was superfluous. By the time Robert Kennedy met Anatoly Dobrynin on 27 October, the Presidium had already accepted Khrushchev's recommendation to withdraw the missiles and create 'a zone of peace'. By the time members of the Presidium learned of Kennedy's undertaking to withdraw the missiles from Turkey and Italy, Khrushchev had already told them it was necessary to retreat 'in order to save the world'.

The offer to withdraw the Jupiters was not necessary to persuade Moscow to take the missiles out of Cuba. There was no way President Kennedy could have known what the Presidium decided on 25 or 28 October. There might have been, if the US had a trusted source of